

know which technologies will fit together for a solution that's appropriate for your client and you have to know how to join all of them together. These are the things that you need to be aware of when you are dealing with open source.

"It is very easy to get stuck with one technology in open source also, which is fine, as one can become an expert in that technology. But eventually, what happens is that clients end up losing out on new technologies, or rather, better technologies, which may be more suitable for their requirements because the service provider is not aware of them. And the awareness comes from interactions with the community—whether it is through RSS feeds, forums or mailing lists," he adds.

Be open to adopting new technologies

Mathur asserts, "The most important thing while consulting in open source is that you should be more open to new technologies than you would be in the proprietary software world, because technology doesn't change so fast in the case of the latter. In the open source world, the technologies get enhanced and mutate really fast."

Be innovative

Over a period of time, it has been noticed that people offering standardised open source solutions do not do as well in the market when compared to those who offer customised solutions. Abhishek Datt, chief technology officer, Taashee Linux Services, says, "I think one should not offer open source solutions that are available off-the-shelf or those that can be downloaded. Instead, one should try to build expertise on particular platforms, customise them and either sell them as solutions, or perhaps implement them and support them. Ideally, it should be something that one has built upon and it should bring some value to the customer. What I have seen is that merely telling the customers that you can support a particular solution doesn't work anymore. One has to add value to the solutions. For example, if you are using Alfresco, you can use it as a platform and build an application on top of it. It impresses customers more and it also gives you an opportunity to expand your business, as satisfied clients will call you often for support. I think start-ups should look for solutions and actually build on top of them rather than telling customers that, 'We are champs in this particular technology and we will support it.' One has to always come up with a value addition."

Making premium modules of open source applications also helps in better revenue generation. Charles Sudarshan Jayawardhane, business consultant, Virtusa Corp, Sri Lanka, explains, "Since open source applications are given free of charge, the revenue margins are very low or next to nothing for the companies. Often, it may even get difficult to cover the costs incurred in the business. Hence, building premium modules on open source applications always helps in revenue generation. If you have built an application which is well

thought of and is the exclusive offering of your company, it will definitely be worth a buy for the clients."

Stay connected with the community

The best way to spread the word about your business is via the community, which is also the best resource when it's time to learn the latest in the technology world. Baskar Selvaraj, chief executive, LinuXpert Systems, says, "As an entrepreneur, it is good to be associated with and participate in all the FOSS events, activities and LUG meetings. It gives your business visibility. I interact with the community often on various platforms to share my experience and knowledge. This helps me in making more contacts both within and outside the community, and it further helps in the growth of my business. I believe that promoting the ideology of GNU/Linux and the value of FOSS always helps in promoting the open source business."

Be ready with reference architecture

Buyers of OSS solutions like to see some implementations before they actually invest in them. Datt emphasises, "I think a lot of people are interested in open source but they are unsure on how to use it; for instance, which one should they use and which one is best avoided, from the many available. If you are planning to offer a solution, keep certain reference architectures of the solutions that have been proven and that work all the time. For example, if you are coming up with a service for a hospital, you should offer something on a proven architecture, and make clear and precise suggestions rather than giving your client hundreds of options. If you are going to build an open source travel and ticketing system, you should factor in the needs of the clients and offer them a customised solution suited to their needs."

Understand licences

Licences are complicated, yet it is extremely important to be on the legal side of things for open source businesses as well. Unfortunately, people in the FOSS world tend to take this important bit for granted. If you have plans to do business with OSS, you should master the finer points of licensing, or hire someone who is a master in this domain. Mathur explains, "Ideally, your trust with open source technology can be of three types. You can deploy open source solutions in your organisation, consult people deploying open source solutions in their organisations, or develop open source solutions. Familiarity with the licensing procedures is extremely important in all three cases. If not, you may end up working with OSS platforms that have incompatible licences and encounter legal problems at any stage." 

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